LIGHTEN YOUR LOAD · AUSTRALIAN PRODUCE GUIDE

🚨 The Dirty Dozen

The 12 Australian produce items with the highest evidence of pesticide contamination. Ranked approximately by strength of Australian-specific evidence - prioritise organic versions, especially for children and during pregnancy.

⚠ **Data note:** Australia has no equivalent to the US Environmental Working Group (EWG) Dirty Dozen program. This guide synthesises all available AU data plus international findings where AU data is absent. Rankings are informed estimates, not definitive science. Absence of AU data does not mean absence of risk — it often means absence of independent investigation.

1 🍓 **Strawberries** — Buy Organic

3 of 31 samples exceeded the legal limit in CHOICE testing (2008). Unpublished government data, obtained under FOI by Guardian Australia, showed dimethoate at up to 90× the Australian MRL. Dimethoate: banned in the EU since 2019; possible human carcinogen (US EPA).

2 🍎 **Apples** — Buy Organic

Highest pesticide detection count in AU monitoring data 2000–2011 (Friends of the Earth AU). The Food Standards Code sets apple residue limits for 136 chemicals. Post-harvest diphenylamine widely used (banned EU).

3 🥬 **Spinach & leafy greens** — Buy Organic

Large surface area absorbs systemic pesticides that cannot be washed off. Consistent highest-risk class globally and in AU monitoring data.

4 🍇 **Grapes** — Buy Organic

6.4% of all AU pesticide detections 2000–2011. Multiple fungicides applied repeatedly. Thin skin — cannot be peeled.

5 🍑 **Stone fruit** — Buy Organic

peaches, nectarines, apricots, plums, cherries (most stone fruit: limited AU data)

Unpublished government data (2013), obtained under FOI by Guardian Australia, found fenthion in AU peaches at unacceptable levels. PFAS fludioxonil found on 90% of peach & plum samples (EWG 2026).

6 🫐 **Blueberries** — Buy Organic

Chlorpyrifos & thiometon detected in AU blueberries (FSANZ 2011). Southern Cross University (2025): 3 samples had dimethoate at levels that could exceed the safe daily intake if eaten daily. APVMA proposed suspending dimethoate use on berries (2025).

7 🍐 **Pears** — Buy Organic

9.5% of all AU pesticide detections 2000–2011 — second only to apples. High fungicide use. Diphenylamine post-harvest (banned EU).

8 🍓 **Raspberries & blackberries** — Buy Organic

91% of blackberry samples had detectable pesticides, avg 4+ per sample (EWG 2026). PFAS bifenthrin detected. Same APVMA dimethoate suspension covers raspberries & blackberries (2025).

9 

Lettuce

Buy Organic

4.1% of all AU pesticide detections 2000–2011. Named in Friends of the Earth Australia report. No outer skin — entire surface is eaten.

10 

Capsicum / bell peppers

Buy Organic

Named in AU ATDS monitoring data. Thin edible skin. Ranks just below the Dirty Dozen globally on overall pesticide toxicity.

11 

Celery

Buy Organic

Named in AU ATDS data. No outer peel — every stalk surface is exposed. Very high surface area-to-volume ratio. 64 different pesticides detected internationally.

12 

Kale & Asian greens

Buy Organic

High pest pressure, systemic pesticide use documented. Limited AU-specific testing but biology identical to highest-risk leafy class. Tops EWG 2026 on toxicity weighting.

🚨 PRIORITISE ORGANIC WHEN…

- → Your children eat it regularly — children absorb more and eliminate pesticides less efficiently than adults
- → It's imported AND on this list — source countries may permit chemicals banned in Australia
- → You are pregnant — especially strawberries, leafy greens, and stone fruit
- → You eat it daily — start with your most frequent items first
- → Budget is limited — focus on items #1–6 where the AU evidence is strongest

Sources: FSANZ ATDS · Friends of the Earth AU (2012) · CHOICE · NRS · APVMA · EWG Shopper's Guide (2026) · Guardian AU FOI · Southern Cross University (2025) · Pesticide Action Australia · Full source list →

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